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Regimental Soldiering

After a brief holiday, I left home in August 1964 to report to the Maratha Light Infantry Regiment Centre (MLIRC) at Belgaum. As the train steamed into the Belgaum railway station, I got into my summer uniform and packed my valise and the black steel trunk. Those contained my only worldly possessions at that point of time. I was received by the duty officer and directed to proceed to the MLIRC officers' mess. Outside the station, there was no transport waiting for me. So the coolie carrying my luggage suggested that I take a tonga instead. The mess was on a small hill and the poor scrawny little horse found the going quite tough! The driver had to dismount and put his shoulder to the wheel and push. I paid him one rupee, a princely sum those days, and he left giving me a salaam. Finally, on reaching the mess, the havaldar (sergeant) offered me a welcome cup of tea. When I asked him to show me my room, he smiled wryly and said, 'No rooms are available and Sir, you will have to make do with a tent!'

One of the mess waiters took my baggage and put it in the tent. It had already begun to drizzle. This drizzle continued for the next three days. I knew of the monsoons but had never experienced anything like this. The low clouds passing around the hills made my abode damp and cold. I sat on my trunk and looked around. The tent was no bigger than a hundred square feet and its interiors were bare; besides a cot and an easy chair, there was a folding table and a camp stool. The only light in the tent was from a single 40-watt bulb hanging by a cable on the centre pole. The uneven floor was covered by light brown coir matting. The attached bathroom was even more luxurious! It was a dingy little tent lit by a 'hurricane